

The Inheritance Tax

Their father had died and left them a farmhouse, a debt, and instructions that could not be followed without conversation.

CEFR Level B2

*Book 4 of 10 • Family Drama / Moral Conflict • Adult Graded
Reader Series*

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About This Book

Setting: A farmhouse in rural Yorkshire. The three siblings' present lives. A solicitor's office.

Genre: Family Drama / Moral Conflict

Characters

- Ellen — 49. The eldest. A GP. Has lived nearby and managed the family's needs for twelve years.
- Dan — 46. The middle sibling. A civil engineer. Lives in Cardiff. Visits rarely.
- Beth — 41. The youngest. An academic. Currently in New Zealand on a research placement.
- The farmhouse — the thing they cannot agree on, and what it represents.

THE INHERITANCE TAX

Page 1 — The Will

Their father had died in March, and it was now June, and they were still unable to agree on what to do with the farm.

This was not, in itself, unusual. The solicitor — a patient woman named Mrs. Harding — had told them at the outset that disputes over inherited property were among the most common and most prolonged she dealt with, and that the emotional complexity of what was ostensibly a financial transaction was frequently underestimated by all parties.

What was slightly unusual, Mrs. Harding had added, was that their father had left a will that was perfectly clear in its dispositions but which contained, in its final clause, a condition that had complicated everything.

The condition was simple: the farm should not be sold within twelve months of his death.

Vocabulary Support

ostensibly	görünürde
dispositions	tasarruflar
solicitor	avukat
underestimated	küçümsenen

prolonged	uzun süren
clause	madde, hüküm

A clear will with one condition: do not sell for twelve months. That condition changed everything.

Page 2 — Ellen

Ellen had been managing the farm — not farming it, but managing it: the maintenance, the tenant farmer who worked the land, the repairs that the old house perpetually required — for the last four years, since their father's first stroke had made it impossible for him to do so himself.

She was, she had told Mrs. Harding with a precision that was more clipped than she had intended, exhausted.

Not by grief — she had been grieving, in incremental ways, for four years, as his capacity had diminished. The acute form of grief was almost a relief.

By the practical weight of the thing, which was now, owing to the twelve-month condition, going to remain on her shoulders for at least another year.

'I don't resent it,' she had said. 'I just want it acknowledged.'

Vocabulary Support

tenant farmer	kiracı çiftçi
perpetually	sürekli olarak
incremental	kademeli
clipped	kısa ve sert

acute grief	akut yas
diminished	azalmıştı

"I just want it acknowledged." Twelve years of carrying it. She wants it seen.

Page 3 — Dan

Dan had flown up from Cardiff for the solicitor's meeting and had stayed for four days, which was four days longer than he had stayed for any visit in the previous three years.

He had spent most of those four days in the farmhouse, going through their father's things with the systematic efficiency he applied to project management — working through drawers and cupboards, labelling boxes, preparing lists.

Ellen had watched him do this with a mixture of gratitude and resentment that she had been too honest with herself not to acknowledge.

Grateful because it needed doing and she had done too much of what needed doing for too long.

Resentful because he was doing it now, when their father was dead, and not during the years when it had mattered differently.

Vocabulary Support

systematic efficiency	sistematik verimlilik
resentment	kırgınlık, gücenme
labelling	etiketleme
acknowledge	kabul etmek
project management	proje yönetimi
doing it now	şimdi yapıyor

Grateful and resentful simultaneously. She was too honest with herself not to acknowledge both.

Page 4 — Beth

Beth had not been able to come for the solicitor's meeting, which was something she had told her siblings and which was true, though the full version of the truth was that she had not tried as hard as she might have to make it possible.

She was in New Zealand on a research placement that was, professionally, important and that could not, in any meaningful sense, have been rescheduled.

She was also, she had admitted to herself in the weeks before the meeting, not sure she was ready to sit in a room with Ellen and Dan and the house and everything the house implied.

She participated by video call, from a kitchen in Auckland, in the early morning, while her siblings sat in a solicitor's office in Yorkshire at four in the afternoon.

The time difference felt, to Beth, like a useful metaphor.

Vocabulary Support

rescheduled	ertelenmek
placement	staj, görev
participated by video call	video konferansla katıldı
implied	ima etti

metaphor	metafor
admitted to herself	kendine kabul etti

The time difference felt like a useful metaphor. She is in a different timezone, and she knows it.

Page 5 — The Twelve Months

The condition — do not sell within twelve months — had been, Mrs. Harding explained, not uncommon in her experience.

Farmers, in particular, tended to include such conditions: they were aware that grief produced bad decisions, that the period immediately following a death was not the period in which to make permanent choices about things that had taken a lifetime to build.

Ellen had understood this. She had also understood that her father had, characteristically, not discussed the condition with her before including it, on the grounds that he had always been more comfortable making decisions than discussing them.

'He wanted to give us time,' Beth said, from Auckland.

'He wanted to give us a reason to talk,' Dan said.

Ellen said nothing. She thought: both of those things are probably true, and neither of them makes it easier.

Vocabulary Support

characteristically	karakteristik biçimde
permanent choices	kalıcı seçimler
on the grounds that	gerekçesiyle

uncomfortable with	... den rahatsız
condition	koşul
grief produces bad decisions	yas kötü kararlar üretir

Both probably true. Neither makes it easier. Ellen says nothing. She thinks instead.

Page 6 — What the Farm Was

What the farm was — what it had been for all three of them, though differently — was something they had each been articulating to themselves, in the weeks since the solicitor's meeting, without having yet said it to each other.

For Ellen, the farm was the place she had never left, which was both a source of rootedness and a reminder of choices she had not made.

For Dan, it was the place he had left — deliberately, with relief, and with a guilt about the relief that had accumulated, over twenty-three years, into something he was not sure how to discharge.

For Beth, it was both: she had left, as Dan had, but had continued to need it as a referent — the place she oriented herself against even from New Zealand.

'It's different for each of us,' she had told a colleague in Auckland. 'That's the problem. We're not disagreeing about the farm. We're disagreeing about what it means.'

Vocabulary Support

rootedness	köklenme
discharge	boşaltmak
referent	referans noktası

articulating	dile getirmek
accumulated	birikmiş
orient against	... e karşı konumlanmak

"We're not disagreeing about the farm. We're disagreeing about what it means." Beth names it from Auckland.

Page 7 — The Debt

The debt complicated everything.

Their father had, it emerged from the solicitor's files, borrowed against the farm to fund repairs in 2018 — a decision he had not mentioned to any of them and which had left, after his death, a secured loan that the estate was required to service.

The loan was not large, in relation to the property's value. It was large in relation to what the estate could generate without the sale of the property.

Dan had been the first to raise it, which had produced in Ellen a reaction she was not entirely proud of.

He was right to raise it. She knew he was right to raise it.

She had still, momentarily and with some force, wanted him not to.

Vocabulary Support

secured loan	teminatlı kredi
service a loan	kredi ödemesi yapmak
emerged	ortaya çıktı
in relation to	... e kıyasla
fund repairs	tamirat finansmanı
estate	mülk, miras

The debt she did not know about. She wanted Dan not to have raised it. He was right to raise it.

Page 8 — The Conversation They Had Not Had

It was Beth who called for it — a direct conversation, not mediated by the solicitor, not structured around the legal and financial options.

She had sent an email that was, Ellen thought, the most carefully worded document she had read since her last contract negotiation.

It said, in substance: we have been treating this as a problem with a financial solution, and it is that, but it is also something else, and I think we need to have the other conversation first, or we will end up solving the financial problem in a way that creates a different problem.

Dan had replied within an hour: yes.

Ellen had taken two days. Then she had written: yes, but not by video call.

Vocabulary Support

mediated by	... aracılığıyla
substance	özünde
carefully worded	özenle ifade edilmiş
creates a different problem	farklı bir sorun yaratır
contract negotiation	sözleşme müzakeresi
direct conversation	doğrudan konuşma

"Not by video call." Ellen's one condition. She will have the hard conversation. But in person.

Page 9 — August

Beth flew back from New Zealand in August, six weeks before the end of her placement.

She had not told the placement coordinator the real reason for the early departure, which she was aware was a form of dishonesty and which she had chosen to accept.

Dan drove up from Cardiff. He arrived the same evening Beth arrived, which was either coincidence or, Beth suspected, coordination — Dan being, among his other qualities, someone who managed logistics in ways that were invisible unless you knew to look for them.

Ellen had cooked. She was a GP — she was not, as a rule, demonstratively hospitable — but she had cooked.

Beth had looked at the food and thought: she has been managing things alone for twelve years, and cooking is one of the ways she is showing us that she knows we are here.

Vocabulary Support

coordinator	koordinatör
departure	ayrılış
logistics	lojistik

demonstratively hospitable	gösterişli biçimde misafirperver
coordination	koordinasyon
invisible unless	fark edilmez, meğerki

She cooked. Beth understood what the food meant. Ellen had been managing alone for twelve years.

Page 10 — The Conversation

They talked for most of two evenings.

The first evening was the difficult one — the one in which the things that had been said inadequately, or not at all, over twelve years, were said adequately.

Ellen said, with a precision and a lack of accusation that Beth afterwards described as the bravest thing she had witnessed in a long time: 'I need you both to understand what these twelve years have cost me. Not so that you feel guilty — I don't want that. So that you understand what I'm asking for in whatever we decide to do.'

Dan said, with a directness that surprised Beth: 'I was not here. I chose not to be. I have spent twelve years knowing that and not knowing how to say it.'

Beth said: 'I was not here either. And I have the additional problem of having been closer and choosing greater distance.'

Vocabulary Support

accusation	suçlama
inadequately	yetersiz biçimde
bravest thing	en cesur şey
witnessed	tanık oldu
additional problem	ek sorun
greater distance	daha büyük mesafe

Three people saying the things that had needed saying for twelve years. Without accusation.

Page 11 — What They Decided

The decision, when it came, took the second evening.

They would not sell within the twelve months — they would honour the condition, and the debt would be managed through a temporary refinancing that Dan had researched and which was affordable if all three contributed.

After twelve months, they would reassess. Ellen would have the option of buying out her siblings at a fair valuation if she wished to keep the farm. If she did not, they would sell.

The arrangement acknowledged something that had not previously been acknowledged: that Ellen's twelve years of proximity were a form of investment that deserved recognition in any equitable distribution.

It was not, Mrs. Harding would later say, a legally unusual arrangement. It was, for this family, a significant one.

Vocabulary Support

refinancing	yeniden finansman
buying out	hisselerini satın almak
equitable distribution	adil dağıtım
proximity	yakınlık
fair valuation	adil değerlendirme
reassess	yeniden değerlendirmek

Her proximity was an investment. The arrangement acknowledged this. Not legally unusual. For them, significant.

Page 12 — Ellen After

Ellen had not expected, after the two evenings, to feel differently.

She had expected to feel relieved — the relief of things said and an arrangement made — and she did feel that.

But she felt something else as well, which was harder to name.

She thought: I have spent twelve years carrying something that I did not adequately communicate to the people who should have been sharing it. Some portion of the weight has been, all along, the uncommunicated weight.

She was not sure what to do with this.

She thought: I have been a good doctor for thirty years. I have been, in many respects, a good eldest sibling.

I have not been, in all respects, good at asking for what I needed.

She wrote this in her diary. She did not show it to anyone.

Vocabulary Support

adequately communicated	yeterince iletişimi kurulmuş
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portion	kısım
uncommunicated weight	iletilmemiş ağırlık
eldest sibling	en büyük kardeş
in many respects	pek çok açıdan
diary	günlük

Some of the weight was the uncommunicated weight. She had not asked for what she needed.

Page 13 — Dan After

Dan had driven back to Cardiff feeling, he told his partner that evening, as though he had been weighed and found not wanting — but only barely.

His partner, who had heard about Ellen and the farm for twelve years, said: 'What does that mean?'

'It means I did something wrong for a long time,' Dan said. 'And I acknowledged it. And my sisters didn't say it was fine — because it wasn't — but they also didn't make it the end of anything.'

'Are you surprised by that?' 'Yes,' he said. 'I thought I'd been absent for long enough that there was nothing to come back to.'

'There was a farm,' his partner said.

'There was more than a farm,' he said.

Vocabulary Support

weighed and found not wanting	tartılıp yetersiz bulunmamak
acknowledged	kabul etti
absent	yoktu
nothing to come back to	geri dönecek bir şey yok
more than a farm	çiftlikten fazlası
barely	zar zor

"There was more than a farm." He had been absent so long he thought there was nothing left.

Page 14 — Beth After

Beth had gone back to New Zealand for the final weeks of her placement and had, in those weeks, found the work easier.

She had thought about this. She had decided that it was because she had set something down that she had been carrying — not the farm itself, but her knowledge that she had not handled the farm well.

She had a tendency, which she had identified in herself over years of therapy and self-analysis, to resolve uncomfortable situations by increasing the distance from them.

The flight to New Zealand was, in retrospect, the longest extension of this tendency she had ever made.

Coming back had been, by some measure, the most difficult thing she had done in several years.

She had also found it, unexpectedly, the most clarifying.

Vocabulary Support

set something down	bir şeyi bırakmak
self-analysis	öz analiz
extension of a tendency	eğilimin uzantısı
clarifying	açıklayıcı
retrospect	geriye dönük bakış

resolve by distance

mesafeyle çözmek

The flight to New Zealand was the longest extension of a tendency she had finally recognised.

Page 15 — The Twelve Months

The twelve months passed.

There were practical negotiations — the debt refinancing, the management of the tenant farmer's contract, two visits to the farm by Dan and one by Beth.

Ellen had, in that year, begun to think differently about the farm — not as a burden exactly, but as a complicated gift.

Her father had built it. He had farmed it badly and maintained it well. He had loved it in the way of someone who is better at tending things than expressing love directly.

She had inherited this quality. She had not, until this year, seen it as something they shared.

She thought: he knew what he was doing with the twelve months.

Vocabulary Support

practically	pratikte
complicated gift	karmaşık bir hediye
tending things	şeylere bakmak
inherited	miras aldı
expressing love	sevgiyi ifade etmek
sharing a quality	bir özelliği paylaşmak

"He knew what he was doing with the twelve months." She finally understands the condition.

Page 16 — The Decision

At the end of twelve months, Ellen did not buy out her siblings.

She had thought she would. She had spent several months assuming she would.

What changed was not the financial calculation — the numbers worked — but something that happened in October, when she had driven past the farm on a Sunday afternoon and had felt, rather than thought, that she no longer wanted to own it.

She wanted to be near it. She wanted to visit it. She did not want to be responsible for it.

This was a distinction she had not known she could draw until she drew it.

She told Dan and Beth by phone, on the same call, a week before the twelve months expired.

'Are you sure?' Beth asked. 'Yes,' Ellen said. 'I think I've been confusing proximity with ownership.'

Vocabulary Support

confusing proximity with ownership	yakınlığı sahiplikle karıştırmak
expired	doldu
financial calculation	finansal hesap
draw a distinction	ayırım yapmak

responsible for	... den sorumlu
assuming	varsayıyordu

"Confusing proximity with ownership." Twelve years of managing. It was not the same as wanting to own.

Page 17 — The Sale

The farm was sold in the spring — not to a developer, as they had feared when the subject first arose, but to a family who had been farming in the area and wanted to expand.

Ellen had met them twice. She had found, in them, the quality of people who knew the land rather than merely owned it.

The sale was, by any external measure, straightforward: a fair price, a reasonable timeline, no complications.

It was, by the internal measure of the three siblings, something more.

Each of them had given up something they had not known they were holding.

Ellen, in retrospect, thought this was what their father had intended — not the twelve months specifically, but what the twelve months had made possible.

Vocabulary Support

developer	inşaatçı
expand	genişlemek
external measure	dışsal ölçü
intended	niyet etmiş

in retrospect	geriye dönük olarak
holding	tuttuğu şey

*Each gave up something they had not known they were holding.
Their father had intended this.*

Page 18 — What the Farm Had Been

Ellen had tried, in a conversation with her therapist the month after the sale, to describe what the farm had been.

She had ended up saying: 'It was a place where the family existed as a family, rather than as the three adult children of parents who were no longer alive. Once it was sold, we had to exist differently.'

'Is that bad?' her therapist had asked.

'No,' Ellen had said. 'It's appropriate. We are three adult children of parents who are no longer alive. We should exist as that, not as a family pretending its centre still holds.'

She had surprised herself with the last phrase.

She had not been sure, until she said it, that she believed it.

She believed it.

Vocabulary Support

therapist	terapist
centre still holds	merkezi hâlâ tutunuyor
pretending	numarası yapan
appropriate	uygun
surprised herself	kendini şaşırttı
longer alive	artık hayatta değil

"The centre still holds" — pretending this. They were not. The farm let them stop pretending.

Page 19 — A Year After

A year after the sale, the three of them went back to Yorkshire — not to the farm, which was now inhabited by people they barely knew, but to the area.

They walked on the moors above the valley for a morning.

This had been Dan's suggestion, which had surprised both of his sisters.

He had said, when he proposed it: 'I want to go back somewhere near it, but not to it. I want to walk somewhere we used to walk.'

They had spent four hours on the moors, talking and not talking in roughly equal measure.

It was, Ellen thought, the first time in many years that they had been somewhere together without a task.

It was, she thought, what families that no longer have a centre learn to do.

Vocabulary Support

inhabited	yaşanan
moors	ıssız tepeler
equal measure	eşit ölçüde
barely knew	pek tanımadıkları
proposed it	önerdi

without a task

bir görev olmaksızın

Together without a task. What families that no longer have a centre learn to do.

Page 20 — The Condition

She had thought, in the two years since her father's death, about the condition — do not sell within twelve months — more than she had thought about any other element of his will.

She had understood it, at first, as a practical measure: a hedge against grief-driven decisions, a period of enforced reflection.

She had come to understand it as something more.

Her father had known that the twelve months would require them to manage something together. He had known that managing something together, after years of not doing so, would require them to talk.

He had known they were not good at talking.

He had been right about all of it.

He had also been, she thought, rather braver than she had given him credit for.

She had not, before the condition, considered him capable of hope.

Vocabulary Support

enforced reflection	zorunlu kılınmış yansıma
hedge against	karşı koruma
grief-driven	yas güdümlü

credit for	... için hak tanımak
capable of hope	umut etmeye muktedir
considered	düşünmüştü

"He had been capable of hope." She had not known this about him until the condition revealed it.

ACTIVITIES

1. Vocabulary Practice — Match the Words

Match each word or phrase with the correct meaning.

Word / phrase	Meaning
1. solicitor	A. kiracı çiftçi
2. tenant farmer	B. avukat
3. resentment	C. kırgınlık
4. equitable	D. adil
5. proximity	E. yakınlık
6. discharge (guilt)	F. boşaltmak
7. clarifying	G. açıklayıcı
8. ostensibly	H. görünürde

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word or phrase from the box.

condition — acknowledged — centre — proximity — hope — together

1. Their father's will contained a _____: the farm could not be sold for twelve months.
2. Ellen said: I just want it _____. Twelve years of management. She wanted it seen.
3. The arrangement recognised that Ellen's _____ was a form of investment.

4. At the end, Ellen said she had been confusing _____ with ownership.

5. Beth's insight was: we are not disagreeing about the farm, we are disagreeing about what it means.

6. After the sale, the three of them found that families without a _____ learn to be together without a task.

3. Comprehension Questions

True or False? Write T or F.

1. The will requires the farm to be sold within twelve months. ____
2. Ellen has been managing the farm for the past four years.

3. Dan had visited the farm frequently in the previous three years. ____
4. Beth participates in the solicitor's meeting in person. ____
5. At the end of twelve months, Ellen buys out her siblings.

6. The farm is eventually sold to a developer. ____

Short Answer Questions

7. What does Ellen mean when she says 'I just want it acknowledged'?
8. Why does Beth fly back from New Zealand early?
9. What does Ellen say during the two-day conversation that Beth describes as the bravest thing she has witnessed?
10. What arrangement do the three siblings reach?
11. What does Ellen realise about herself in the year after the conversation?
12. Why does Ellen decide not to buy out her siblings at the end of twelve months?
13. What does Ellen mean by 'confusing proximity with ownership'?

14. What does Ellen mean when she says they were 'pretending the centre still holds'?

15. What does Ellen realise about her father from the condition in the will?

ANSWER KEY

(Alıştırmaları yaptıktan sonra bakınız.)

Match: 1-B 2-A 3-C 4-D 5-E 6-F 7-G 8-H

Fill in the Blanks: 1. condition 2. acknowledged 3. proximity 4. proximity 5. meaning 6. centre

True / False: 1. F 2. F 3. F 4. F 5. F 6. F

7. She wants her siblings to understand what the twelve years of managing the farm alone have cost her — not so they feel guilty, but so that her investment is recognised in whatever decision they make.

8. Because she realises that she needs to have the difficult conversation with her siblings in person, and because she acknowledges that her distance has been partly a choice rather than a necessity.

9. She says without accusation: 'I need you both to understand what these twelve years have cost me — not so you feel guilty, but so you understand what I'm asking for in whatever we decide.'

10. They honour the twelve-month condition, manage the debt through shared refinancing, and give Ellen the option to buy out her siblings at fair valuation. If she does not, they will sell.

11. That some of the weight she had been carrying was the uncommunicated weight — she had not adequately asked for what she needed.

12. She feels, rather than thinks, that she no longer wants to own it — she wants proximity, not responsibility.

13. She had been managing the farm for twelve years but mistook that management — proximity — for a desire to own it.

14. They had been treating the farm as the centre that held them together as a family, when in fact they were three adult children of deceased parents, and needed to acknowledge this changed reality.

15. That he had been capable of hope — he knew the twelve months would force them to talk, and he hoped they would use the time to do what they had not done for years.